

Heilman Auto Group

Ardmore · West Chester · Hatboro, Pennsylvania · Established 1986

PREPARED FOR **Jack Heilman, Owner**
SUBJECT **Margin recovery & shop-floor efficiency**
DATE **June 2026**

Three core margin levers plus the moves that enable them, each modeled on conservative assumptions. Two require zero capital and can move this week. Every dollar figure is directional and should be re-run against live repair-order, payroll, and parts-invoice data before final commitment.

WHAT'S INSIDE

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| 1 | Margin Recovery Brief
The three levers on one page — labor rate, shop supplies, Tekmetric — and the combined opportunity. | ~\$545K / yr |
| <hr/> | | |
| 2 | The Reason Why
Each recommendation stripped to the single justification an owner can repeat to a skeptic. | 5 moves |
| <hr/> | | |
| 3 | Calculator Snapshots
The inputs and headline math behind each lever — labor rate, Tekmetric ROI, shop supplies fee. | 3 models |
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These projections use conservative baselines — 9 productive techs, a 50-week year, and current volume of ~600 ROs/month. The math holds up, but run it against exact payroll and parts-invoice data before pulling the trigger. Each lever stands alone; the Shop Supplies recovery is counted once and kept out of the Tekmetric figure, so nothing is double-counted.

Three independent levers, each modeled on conservative inputs. The numbers below are directional — every figure is adjustable in the live calculators and should be re-run against real RO, payroll, and parts-invoice data before final commitment.

1

Labor Rate Update

\$139 → \$170 / hr

+\$446K

per year · +\$37.2K/mo

Nearly all margin — almost no added cost

14,400 billed hrs × \$31 uplift

Same wrenches, same bays

Needs: online booking + proof of your real rate

2

Shop Supplies Fee

7% of labor · capped \$40

+\$54K

per year · +\$4.5K/mo

No upfront cost — automated by the system

Recovers consumables automatically & seamlessly

Recovers consumables without small line items

Trust win + margin in one move

3

Tekmetric Shop System

~\$1,500/mo (est.) · 3 locations

8.6 days

to pay for itself / month

\$3.48 back on every \$1

+\$44.5K/yr net — labor recovery alone

Bulletproof PA-compliant audit trail

Idle-bay + collections = pure upside

COMBINED ANNUAL OPPORTUNITY — DIRECTIONAL, SEPARATE LEVERS, NO DOUBLE-COUNT

~\$545K / yr

Labor Rate	+ \$446,400
Shop Supplies	+ \$53,712
Tekmetric (net)	+ \$44,550

EXECUTION SEQUENCE

- 1

Pilot Tekmetric — start now. Run it at a single shop first; it hardcodes the supplies fee and authorizations, so there's no manual error. Techs use their own phones, so there's no tablet to buy. Pays for itself by the 9th.
- 2

Shop Supplies Fee — once the system's in. Let Tekmetric auto-apply the 7% (capped \$40) so it's exact and PA-compliant every time. Disclose on the estimate and with signage.
- 3

Labor rate to \$170 — once the new site and proof of your real rate are in hand. The big lever. Roll it out alongside the video inspection — not the same month as the supplies fee — so customers see new value, not just a higher price.

NON-NEGOTIABLE: PA COMPLIANCE

ITEMIZE AND DOCUMENT.
Every estimate must be exact, itemized, and carry documented pre-authorization. A disputed estimate without signed authorization loses 100% of the time. The shop-supplies fee must appear as its own disclosed line. Tekmetric's timestamped digital authorization turns that compliance risk into a documented, protected record.

These build on the reputation Jack and the team have spent nearly four decades earning. None of them change what works — they carry that hard-won trust forward into how the shops price, book, and protect their work. Each move, with the one reason it earns its place.

1 Raise the labor rate — \$139 → \$170/hr

Nearly all margin · +\$446K/yr

Joe Kranz — my old boss — just opened his own shop, Kranz Motors in Kennett Square, at \$170/hr, and he's holding it, not discounting it back. He's not alone: comparable Main Line and Chester County independents have already climbed past your current rate. You've held steady for years — but four decades of earned trust have more than justified the right to match the market. Moving to \$170 adds **almost no cost** — no extra parts, labor, or bay time — so nearly all drops to the bottom line.

BOTTOM LINE

This isn't reaching — it's catching up to a market that's already moved past you.

2 Roll fluids into a Shop Supplies Fee — 7% of labor, capped \$40

No upfront cost · +\$54K/yr · automated by the system

Itemizing small consumables like washer fluid or a half-quart of oil recovers pennies, but it can rub a loyal customer the wrong way. Rolling them into a single **capped shop-supplies fee** recovers the same cost quietly across the ticket — and frees the team to keep giving away the small stuff that builds goodwill, the goodwill that brings the \$1,500 jobs back.

BOTTOM LINE

A small structural fee protects the margin and the relationship at the same time.

3 Add a shop-management system across all 3 shops

~\$1,500/mo (est.) · pays for itself by the 9th · \$3.48 back per \$1

The shops have run on paper and built a loyal following doing it — but across three locations, paper makes it easy to lose the last 0.2 hours of diag or cleanup, and it can't timestamp a digital authorization. A system like Tekmetric captures that work automatically, ends the phone-vs-online double-bookings that leave bays idle, and turns every authorization into a clean, PA-compliant record. MacLane Auto runs all three of its locations on Tekmetric and swears by it — a shop your size, already proving it works. The recovered time alone covers the cost in the **first week and a half of each month**.

BOTTOM LINE

Paper got the shops this far. A system is what lets them grow without losing the details.

4 Free quick look, paid testing — diagnostics start at one hour (\$170)

Free triage · real testing billed · higher close on the repair

A fast visual look stays free — that's the hook that gets a customer to leave the car, and that's half the battle. But the moment it needs real testing — a scope, a smoke test, tracing a CAN-bus fault or EVAP leak — that's a full hour of labor, \$170, because it uses the most expensive tools and the most skilled hands in the building. **No more giving away the answer**. Pairing the testing with a **video multi-point inspection — built right into Tekmetric's DVI** — makes the fee easy to understand: the tech records the fault on their own phone and sends it straight to the customer, and when they see the problem on screen, they approve the repair with confidence.

BOTTOM LINE

Give away the look, never the answer. Charge for the testing — and let the video prove it's worth every penny.

5 Modernize online booking — the redesign's already built

Mockup done · connect to the shop system next

MacLane Auto, run by an old colleague I spent five years with at Volkswagen, lets a customer book an appointment in two clicks — no friction — and that's where modern shops are winning the booking. Yours can't match that yet. So I built an updated version to work alongside you: it keeps the original 1986 logo and branding, lets a customer **book in two taps**, and feeds straight into the shop system — no more phone tag. It also does what the current site can't: take a PA-compliant digital authorization and deliver the video inspection that lifts the average repair order. (Mocked up and ready to show, with the real shop photos and customer reviews front and center.)

BOTTOM LINE

I built it on the brand you've always had, not over it. Connect it to the shop system and it goes live.



Scan to see
the live preview

A good plan dies on the shop floor if it's rushed. These four moves protect the regulars, the crew, and the front desk — so the numbers in this playbook actually show up in the bank.

1 Start with one shop — prove it, then expand

30-day pilot · then roll to the other two

Don't flip all three locations at once. Run the new shop system and pricing at **one shop first**, iron out the kinks, and show the revenue lift over 30 days. Then take that real, in-house proof to the other two — the older techs and writers adjust on a small stage, not all at once, and you've got numbers instead of a promise.

BOTTOM LINE

One shop, 30 days, real proof — then scale what already worked.

2 Protect the loyalists — a 90-day grandfather

New rate for new customers now · regulars eased in

The \$170 rate applies to **new customers immediately**. For the 20- and 30-year regulars, the writer can say: *"Our rate moved to \$170, but Jack wanted to honor your old rate for today's service."* It makes Jack the hero, moves the customer mentally to the new number, and gets the shop to \$170 over 90 days without burning a single bridge.

BOTTOM LINE

Loyal customers feel taken care of, not cashed in on.

3 Arm the front desk — or they'll discount it away

One confident sentence per new charge

A service writer who can't explain a fee will give it away to avoid conflict — and there go the margins. Give them simple, confident lines:

Supplies fee: *"That's our shop-supplies & disposal charge — it covers fluids, rags, and cleanup so we're not nickel-and-diming you on every little item."*

Diagnostic (free look, paid testing): *"Happy to take a quick look and tell you what we're seeing — that part's on us. If it needs real testing to pin down the cause, that's a master tech and the scope, so it starts at one hour, and you'll get a video of the problem before you approve any repair."*

BOTTOM LINE

Train the words, or the margin walks out the front door.

4 Sequence the changes — never all at once

Fee + system first · rate later, with the video

Roll the supplies fee and the shop system in first — they're quiet and customers barely notice. Bring the **rate increase later**, launched alongside the video inspection, so customers see obvious new value, not just a higher price. Never the new rate and the new fee in the same month — that's the one combination that triggers sticker shock.

BOTTOM LINE

Stagger it so every price change arrives with visible new value.

Effective Labor Rate — Revenue Recovery

What an hour at \$170 instead of \$139 brings back.

INPUTS

PRODUCTIVE TECHS 9	BILLED HRS / TECH / WEEK 32	WORKING WEEKS / YEAR 50
CURRENT RATE \$139	PROPOSED RATE \$170	ANNUAL BILLED HOURS 14,400

REVENUE RECOVERY — SAME WRENCHES, SAME BAYS		
ADDED / MONTH \$37,200	ADDED / YEAR \$446,400	ADDED MARGIN ~95%

Current revenue @ \$139 (14,400 hrs)	\$2,001,600
Proposed revenue @ \$170	\$2,448,000
Recovered gross margin / year	+ \$446,400

BOTTOM LINE
The rate increase carries almost no added cost — no extra parts, labor, or bay time. It's the highest-margin lever on the board.

The added revenue is simply your billed hours x the \$31 rate increase. Calculated exactly to the penny; replace inputs with live shop data before commitment.

Tekmetric ROI — Days to Payback

Conservative, labor-recovery only. Consumables counted once in the Shop Supplies model, so nothing is double-counted.

INPUTS

COST / LOCATION / MONTH

\$500

LOCATIONS

3

SYSTEM COST / MONTH (EST.)

\$1,500

PRODUCTIVE TECHS

9

LOST HRS / TECH / WEEK

1.0

LABOR RATE · WEEKS

\$139 · 50

IT PAYS FOR ITSELF IN THE FIRST WEEK AND A HALF OF EVERY MONTH

DAYS TO PAYBACK

8.6

RETURN / \$1 SPENT

\$3.48

BREAK-EVEN

10.8 hrs/mo

Recovered unbilled labor / year

+ \$62,550

Tekmetric system cost / year

− \$18,000**Net annual gain****+ \$44,550****BOTTOM LINE**

Paper got the shops this far — a system captures the work paper can't, and pays for itself by the 9th. Not counted here, all upside: idle-bay recovery, faster collections, and the PA-compliant audit trail.

Based on recovering just 1.0 lost hour per tech per week — on paper it's easy to miss the last 0.2 hours of diag or cleanup. Capturing that time alone covers the system's monthly cost by the 9th of every month; everything else — idle-bay recovery and faster collections — is pure upside.

Shop Supplies Fee — Margin & Goodwill

Recover consumables automatically while giving away the \$3 top-offs.

INPUTS

REPAIR ORDERS / MONTH 600	AVG LABOR / RO \$278	CONSUMABLES / RO \$12
FEE — % OF LABOR 7.0%	HARD CAP / RO \$40	BREAK-EVEN FEE % 4.3%

NET MARGIN AFTER RECOVERING CONSUMABLES COST		
NET / REPAIR ORDER \$7.46	NET / MONTH \$4,476	NET / YEAR \$53,712

Fee charged / RO (7% of \$278, under cap)	\$19.46
Consumables cost recovered / RO	— \$12.00
Net margin / RO	+ \$7.46

BOTTOM LINE
A small structural fee protects the margin and the relationship at the same time. No capital — the system applies it automatically.